

Section 14 – Living Website Rules

STATUS: APPROVED

Purpose

The CLA Brand & Design Language is a living system designed to evolve intentionally while preserving the identity of the CLA website.

Its purpose is to ensure that every future improvement strengthens the website rather than fragmenting it.

Design Evolution

- * Every new page, feature, or component should follow the existing CLA Design Language by default.
- * The Design Language serves as the foundation for all future work.
- * Designers and developers should build within the established system rather than creating independent visual styles.
- * Consistency across years of development is a core objective.

Design System Authority

- * The CLA Brand & Design Language OS is the official source of truth for all visual and interaction design decisions.
- * Future work should extend the existing Design Language rather than replace it unless intentionally approved.

Design Improvements

- * Continuous improvement is encouraged.
- * Small improvements that remain consistent with the CLA Design Language may be introduced naturally.
- * Major changes to colors, typography, layouts, components, motion, accessibility, or interaction patterns should be intentionally reviewed before becoming official standards.

Design Evolution Reviews

The CLA Design Language will be formally reviewed every six months.

Each review evaluates:

- * User Experience (UX)

- * User Interface (UI)
- * Accessibility
- * Performance
- * Component Library
- * Mobile Experience
- * Desktop Experience
- * Ministry Feedback
- * Visitor Feedback
- * Emerging Technologies
- * Photography
- * Motion & Animation
- * Opportunities to simplify or improve the Design Language

The purpose of these reviews is to ensure the website continues to improve without losing its identity.

Design Flexibility

- * Flexibility is encouraged.
- * Consistency is even more important.
- * Innovation should strengthen—not weaken—the CLA identity.
- * Every proposed improvement should be evaluated against the existing Design Language before becoming part of it.

Living Documentation

This OS is intended to remain a living document.

Every significant design decision should be documented, including:

- * New components
- * Layout systems
- * Typography updates
- * Color additions
- * Motion principles
- * Accessibility standards
- * Interaction patterns
- * Governance decisions

Future designers and developers should understand both:

- * What the standards are
- * Why they exist

Resolving Design Conflicts

There should only ever be one official rule for any design decision.

When a proposal conflicts with an existing rule:

1. Discuss the conflict.
2. Evaluate advantages and disadvantages.
3. If the new solution is genuinely better, update the Design Language.
4. Replace the previous rule rather than creating competing standards.

The CLA Design Language should remain clear, consistent, and easy to follow.

Project Ownership

The Project Owner has final authority over the CLA Brand & Design Language.

Recommendations from:

- * Designers
- * Developers
- * Ministry Leaders
- * Volunteers
- * AI Assistants
- * Contributors

are encouraged and should always be considered thoughtfully.

Final decisions regarding:

- * Visual identity
- * User experience
- * Components
- * Colors
- * Typography
- * Motion
- * Accessibility
- * Future evolution
- * Governance

belong to the Project Owner.

The purpose is not to reject ideas.

The purpose is to preserve one unified long-term vision.

Innovation Philosophy

The CLA website encourages innovation.

New ideas may be implemented directly on the live website when the Project Owner believes they genuinely improve the experience.

Innovation should remain thoughtful and purposeful—not experimental for its own sake.

Every new feature should:

- * Improve the visitor experience.
- * Preserve the CLA identity.
- * Remain consistent with the Design Language whenever possible.

If a successful innovation changes the long-term direction of the website, the CLA Brand & Design Language OS should be updated during the next six-month review.

Timeless Innovation

The CLA website should strive to be timeless while remaining aware of modern design trends.

The goal is not to chase every trend nor ignore innovation.

Instead, adopt ideas that genuinely improve:

- * User experience
- * Accessibility
- * Performance
- * Visual quality
- * Clarity
- * Engagement

Short-lived design fads should generally be avoided.

Long-lasting improvements that represent the future of good design are encouraged.

Before adopting a new trend, ask:

1. Does it improve the visitor experience?
2. Will it still feel modern several years from now?
3. Does it strengthen the CLA identity?
4. Does it fit naturally within the existing Design Language?

If the answer is yes, it deserves serious consideration.

AI Collaboration

AI is a creative partner—not the decision maker.

AI tools such as:

- * ChatGPT
- * GitHub Copilot
- * Codex

- * Claude
- * Future AI Assistants

should assist with:

- * Brainstorming
- * User Experience
- * Code Generation
- * Reviews
- * Suggestions
- * Automation
- * Increasing development speed and quality

AI should never replace:

- * The Project Owner's vision
- * Human judgment
- * Intentional design decisions

Final creative, technical, and strategic decisions always belong to the Project Owner.

AI exists to amplify creativity—not define the CLA identity.

Collaboration & Decision Making

Healthy discussion is encouraged.

Designers, developers, ministry leaders, volunteers, and AI assistants should feel comfortable presenting alternative ideas.

Different perspectives often lead to stronger solutions.

Once the Project Owner has made a final decision:

- * That decision becomes the official direction.
- * All contributors should align with that decision.
- * Respectful collaboration is encouraged.
- * Fragmented implementation is not.

Future Versions

Every future version of the CLA website should build upon this Design Language rather than starting over.

Version 2, Version 3, and future releases should improve:

- * User Experience
- * Accessibility
- * Performance

- * Design Quality
- * Content Organization
- * Ministry Support

Major redesigns should occur only when they provide meaningful benefits while remaining faithful to the CLA identity.

Long-Term Identity

No matter how many years pass or how many people contribute to the CLA website:

Visitors should immediately recognize it as CLA.

The website should maintain one clear and consistent identity across:

- * Every page
- * Every ministry
- * Every campaign
- * Every future version

Every contributor should strengthen the existing Design Language rather than introduce competing styles.

A visitor should never be able to tell which designer or developer created a page.

The experience should feel as though it was crafted by one unified team.

Guiding Principle

People should recognize CLA before they recognize the designer.

Final Statement

The CLA Brand & Design Language exists to guide thoughtful evolution—not constant redesign.

It provides a framework that allows innovation while preserving consistency, craftsmanship, authenticity, and the mission of the church.

It should continue growing alongside the ministry for many years while remaining the single source of truth for how CLA designs, builds, and evolves its digital experiences.
